prospects. Countries such as ‘Ukraine, Kazakhstan and others’ stood out most prominently in this regard.

By 2008, Tata Tea was selling a wide variety of items beyond tea and therefore, it seemed appropriate to change its name. During that year’s AGM, Ratan said that Tata Tea had ceased to be a plantation enterprise and was now ‘more of an FMCG company’. With the company’s presence in different beverages from water to coffee, the ‘current name may not be relevant’. The objective was to transform Tata Tea into ‘an integrated beverage company’. He added that towards this goal, it would be open to make ‘acquisition[s] anywhere in the world’.

The ‘acquisitions would be strategic [ones] that would add particular strength, [a] footprint in another country or access to technology. Mergers and acquisitions, or investments would be made, which make strategic value for us,’ Ratan elaborated. With the company already boasting ‘42 brands in 45 countries’, Krishna Kumar announced that it would now eye ‘markets in America and Russia in a big way and could even look at acquisitions’.

In 2009, Tata Tea finally entered the Russian market, snapping up a 51 per cent stake, along with the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD), in Grand Business, a Russian beverages company. While Tata Tea acquired a 33.2 per cent stake, EBRD bought 17.8 per cent. During the year, Tata Tea also pushed for expansion of its existing brands and relaunched Tata Tea Gold in the Indian market and Tetley in the Middle East.

In July 2010, the company changed its name to Tata Global Beverages Limited (TGBL). During the year’s AGM, Ratan told the shareholders that the name of the company was changed to reflect the transformation in the nature of the business of the company.

Krishna Kumar explained that the rechristening reflected two new dimensions. The first was the company’s presence in several geographies, making it a global brand, and second, that it was not dealing in tea and coffee alone any more. The company was now ‘focused on delighting consumers across the world with great-tasting branded “good for you” beverages. It also demonstrates our pride in our Tata parentage and signals our intention to build a new and strong corporate brand within the Tata Group,’ he said.